

Creating Space

For being **More You**

A practice for modern women **Who want less, but better**

The tension begins. You stretch to balance who you are with what 'they' need.

Having a child is a very special thing for every woman. Bringing a new life into this world is no small feat – it requires incredible amounts of mental fortitude, physical endurance, and lots of patience among other things.

We speak so often of the birth of a child, but rarely the birth of a mother.

A woman's body changes with hormones affecting the way we think. Often we fail to find the time to relax and stop worrying about everything.

From the moment the baby is born, a mother is already in love with it. It's biological. And so, every struggle that we have had to go through suddenly seems so trivial. Hard-wired by nature, new mothers cannot help but feel unconditional love for their adorable little beings that emerged from their own perfect environment- their bodies.

As mum mode sets in, the beauty and the romance of being a mum (some day) settles away and what becomes clear is how much has changed. How what was yours before, is no longer yours. Your time. Your space. Your body. Your thoughts. The mum's job is a little different from the mother's; while a new mother focuses mostly on taking care of her child, mums have to do it all.

Mums are the pillar of a household and take it upon themselves to care for the baby and the whole family as well. If you're a mum, you're probably already familiar with the responsibilities.

Your own life takes a backseat and everything that you do starts to revolve around the happiness and health of your family. You start putting effort into doing things that you would have never done before for yourself. Every moment that you are awake, you are always thinking about your kids, your partner, or your parents.

There's nothing to say that this is the wrong way to live your life. After all, caring about your family is only natural and there's no wrong way to do it.

"You're always going to wonder if you're doing things wrong, but that's what it means to be a mom, to care so much about someone else that you just want to be perfect as possible." –

Naya Rivera

But there is a cost.

Have you thought to yourself – *"I don't remember why I was doing this? All I ever wanted was to be a mum. This was supposed to make me feel happy and fulfilled. I've forgotten who I was supposed to be, how I was supposed to feel."*

Stress and exhaustion can start taking a toll on your physical and mental health. The constant workload along with a lack of attention to yourself can slowly start making you feel as if something is constantly sucking the energy out of you.

This body and mind that you have is with you for the long haul. And running ragged to intercept and meet the needs of everyone around you is getting you no further forward. It never ends.

There's nothing unnatural about this – women all over the globe suffer from this feeling as they feel trapped within the life of a mum. Negative emotions are a healthy part of life. It's when you internalise them and carry the weight of the world on your shoulders with no rest in sight that these negative emotions can cause friction and discomfort in your relationships with family, friends, children, and other people you hold close.

These internalised negative emotions can contribute to increasing your stress levels everyday as you try to cope with the weight that you carry on your shoulders. The expectations that people in your life, especially your family and colleagues, have from you can be difficult to respond to, especially when you're constantly feeling stressed by all of it.

It's understandable that you want to be the best version of yourself to anyone in your life, but it's when you take things too far that it starts turning sour and bitter. Before you start taking on the emotional labour of being "everything to everyone", make sure that you are satisfied with yourself. The way you choose to 'be' is a choice you get to make, and depending on how you make that choice, your life can feel either restrictive or liberating.

What if I told you that with small steps and a simple approach, you could create the life that you've always wanted for yourself without having to sacrifice everything that you've worked so hard for?

The aim of this book is to help you, the reader, achieve this exactly. Throughout this book, we will look at the art and practice of creating an environment, space or place in your home or work that cultivates presence, inspiration, and renewal.

The choices we make about creating zones that are for different purposes; spaces that are for yourself, for your work, for your hobbies, for meeting your own deep human needs has an impact on every aspect of your life.

[What we will step through]

- **Understand your needs** and how those needs apply to the spaces you have created in your life.
- Define the experiences that you want to have in your life and in your spaces. **Engage your senses** with purpose to bring those experiences to life. Make moments matter and connect with your intention – creativity, self care, productivity, learning and growth...
- Set boundaries physically or emotionally to bring focus and intention to your time. Reiterate the **purpose of the time and space** that you create. Be that professional, personal, family, connection, creativity. Without shame for what you are *not doing*, celebrate the focus and dedication of the time that you give to different purposes.
- **Create rituals** and simple actions that make it easy to create space for yourself – to remind you of your intention and guide your day.

What creating space means

We all live our lives in different spaces – there's space for work, for family, friends, and so on. For almost any activity that you regularly participate in with other people, there's a different space that brings different emotions and actions out of you.

Creating space and time in this context refers to the action of dividing up in your mind and understanding what each of them offers you. This calls for curating and choreographing different experiences within your space that prioritise your specific needs.

There are several benefits of doing this:

- You set intention and purpose for different parts of your life. Including specific environments, spaces or parts of spaces in your home or work.
- You use your environment to foster the right mindset to achieve your desired goal. For example, a room flooded with natural light and a nice clear table to scribble and craft something creative.
- Your environment becomes a visual cue to remind you of your intention. We create moments within our space to trigger the desired state and emotions that we wish to experience.
- You take an active ownership of your time and how you choose to give it to yourself and others.

So, let's grab a cup of coffee and get started already, shall we?

1. What You Need

As a working mum, you're juggling lots of different priorities at any given moment, even before your head has left the pillow in the morning. Tackling them all at once can feel overwhelming and the tension in the balance can feel so tight, you think it's going to snap and fall in a heap.

What you really need to do is create some space around all of your "priorities". Sure, at first, everything seems important. But once you start analysing them, you'll probably find that some of them are more of a priority than others. Understanding that "ranking" of priorities is key to finding out what's really important for you.

Start by asking yourself some questions. Questions such as:

- What exactly are these things?
- Which ones are the most important?
- How much time do they take?
- Do you *really* need to do them?
- Could people chip in and help?

I think you get the picture.

Reflecting on your answers to these questions will give you the preliminary analysis of how your spaces work. A critical practice is to **zoom out**. Just for a tick. Zoom out and see the buckets of stuff that are taking up your time.

It's not all work. You love so much of it. It's what you always wanted. But of course, there's also going to be work – work that sucks and zaps your energy. These are things that drain the most of your energy throughout the day.

What are these things? Which aspects of them drain your energy? What can you do about them?

Tease it all out. Scribble it all down in a notebook. Bringing these answers to writing will make it more “visible”.

Understanding your own needs

Let’s face it, you’ll probably have a lot of things on the list that you just made that are not exactly for yourself. Let’s save them for later.

Start by analysing what’s important to you. What your needs are. Ask yourself which of these priorities are for you.

Life is quite demanding and depending on your situation, you are probably going to have different needs. For example, if you spend too much time at work, you probably need to take more breaks.

To understand more about your needs, start by finding out points of friction in your life. These are the situations that you’re not exactly comfortable with or ones that drain you of your energy the most. Once you recognize these points, analyse what exactly contributes to the friction and what you need to reduce it.

Here are a few points to help you with the process:

- Keep a written record of whatever you’re analysing.
- You’re allowed to be a bit selfish – so don’t hold yourself back.
- Divide your needs into categories of priority.
- Understanding your needs is not enough – you also need to figure out how to meet these needs.

Self acknowledgement leads to better output

Self acknowledgement is a powerful motivator that many overlook as an ingredient in the recipe for personal success. Being aware of your

accomplishments and understanding your value as an individual are traits that everyone should be developing in order to get the most out of their work and private lives.

When you're satisfied with your life, you are more likely to focus on your work. You feel a sense of achievement when you accomplish something, which can help keep you motivated. And because we feel a sense of accomplishment when we do our best, we'll want to do more of it in the future.

The key is to find a way to make yourself feel good about yourself—whether that's through exercise, spending time with friends or family members who make you laugh, or even just learning about something new!

So, make sure to enjoy your work and enjoy your life away from work. Life is much more than earning money or being useful to your boss or the team. It's about making happy memories and being the person that the people in your life want you to be.

Whether you choose to work as a mom or not, do not be shy about spending time with your family and kids. At the end of the day, creating space for work is all about being focused on work so that you can come home to your family without having to bring your work into it. The more you enjoy the time with them and make sure that they do too, the more you'll be able to bring out the best version of yourself that your work demands!

2. How time flies

As a working mom, time is of incredible essence to us. Being unable to manage time properly is what sets so many of us back from being able to achieve the life that we want for ourselves. "Time flies" – or so we like to say ourselves. But we all know for a fact that time is fair to us all and it is up to us to decide what we want to do with it.

What is it about time?

You cannot make more time, so what do you want to do with the time you have? It's time to have a clear purpose and actions that align to your genuine intention.

Immortality has been a dream of mankind for so long. It's been romanticised in many ways because having all the time in the world is something that none of us can fathom in real life. But not having the luxury of immortality is also what gives our lives meaning.

Like all things in this universe, we are granted a limited amount of time to do what we are here to do. None of us can create more time – it just simply doesn't work that way. And that's why, it is so important that we understand how we want to spend the time that has been given to us.

Analyse your schedule

The very first step of managing your time involves analysing how you spend your time and understanding how just a handful of decisions can affect your day's schedule. Start by mapping out where and how you spend most of your time. Once you have done that, it becomes a lot easier to see what is worth spending so much time on and what isn't. The law of the vital few

and the trivial many, also known as the Pareto Principle, can really help you put that distinction into practice.

The Pareto Principle states that around 80% of the consequences are a result of 20% of the causes. To put it simply, about 20% of the decisions that you make throughout the day will have a direct impact on around 80% of your day's events. Understanding this principle is important because this allows you to focus on being in control of the things that actually matter.

Trying to be in control of everything can be incredibly exhausting. But thanks to the Pareto Principle, we know that we don't need to. When analysing how you spend your time, try to figure out what your 20% is – which are the decisions that drive your day.

Pareto's rule also states that around 20% of your efforts contribute to 80% of the results. Analysing what that 20% is for you and focusing more on that can really help in "allocating" your daily efforts more effectively for better results.

As an example, for some people, waking up early can be a great way to improve their mood throughout the day and boost their efficiency at work. For them, the decision to wake up early is a part of the 20%. Try experimenting with the decisions that you make everyday and find out what works for you best.

How much time is enough time?

The Parkinson's Law states that work can expand to fill the time allotted for its completion and understanding this law can drastically change how you schedule your day. To put it simply, when you allocate more time to a task than is needed, chances are that you are going to end up using that time even if you could finish it quicker. For example, if you need about 5 minutes

to finish an assignment but decide that you'll get it done in 20, you're likely to take up 20 minutes instead of 5.

You can use this law to experiment with how you schedule your tasks by allocating less time to them than you normally would. While allocating very little time to something can lead to a decrease in the work quality, allocating just the right amount of time can help you reduce the time you need to complete a task without compromising on its quality.

The "right amount of time", however, is something that you'll have to experiment with and find out for yourself because everyone's abilities are different and the time we need to do something changes with our abilities and our proficiency in the task.

Tame the to-do list

One way to keep track of tasks and make sure you're staying on top of your work is through the usage of to-do lists. They also help you avoid distractions, which can help you achieve more in less time.

Here are some important benefits of using a to-do list:

- They make it easier to stay organised

When you have a list of things that need to get done, it becomes easier to stay focused on the task at hand instead of getting distracted by other things.

- They help you prioritise your work

Having a list helps you figure out what needs to be done first, which makes it easier for you to decide what needs more attention or less attention than another item on your list.

- They help you create a schedule for yourself

This can help you get things done even if there isn't enough time in the day (or week). This means that even if something comes up during the week that throws you off your schedule, there will still be time left over for other things because everything is accounted for beforehand! Plus, having a schedule will help you keep track of where you're at in terms of getting things done.

- **Lists help prevent procrastination**

When we write down our tasks and set deadlines for ourselves, it becomes much more difficult to put them off until later.

Stick to your schedule

Treat this as a gift to yourself. By setting clear boundaries and setting expectations for yourself and others, you empower yourself with that sense of space to focus and achieve the things that you are intent on.

- **Get rid of all possible distractions:**

Distractions are the bane of every good schedule. To be able to finish your work within the time that you allot to it, make sure that you keep away anything that might distract you, including your smartphone.

- **Be realistic about your schedule:**

When allocating time to your tasks, make sure that you don't allot too much or too little time. Allocating too much time to a task can result in waste of time, while allocating too little can cause you to miss your deadlines and lose motivation.

- **Identify priority tasks:**

Prioritise the tasks that are important and get them done early on. This helps you stay on track and also feel motivated to complete the other tasks.

- **Be flexible with your time:**

Things often don't go as we plan, and a good plan takes that into consideration. A little flexibility when it comes to following your schedule won't hurt you and in fact, can help you stay on the right track..

Addressing the things a women *should* do

The pursuit of a balanced lifestyle is so familiar. A life where the activities and efforts in running a household are shared equally. The tricky thing is that the balance is what you make it. We're not all the same, but it becomes easier when we acknowledge the efforts in life that we choose to take on, those that we have not choice about and the others that we seek help with from partners, family or other contributors.

Chores and unpaid work

This will probably surprise no one, but all over the world, women are the ones who take up most of the unpaid care work. According to the International Labour Organization, about 76 percent of the total hours of total unpaid work are done by women all over the world. Put simply, women take on unpaid care work about three times as much as men. In Asia and the Pacific, this percentage can go up to about 80% in certain countries.

Over the last few decades, women all around the world have begun understanding the importance of personal freedom and independence. Still, when it comes to household chores, it is usually the women who have to take up the responsibility. And it's only natural that handling all of these responsibilities can end up being too much to handle sometimes.

Instead, what we can do is understand our own capabilities and learn not to overdo things when we reach that limit.

- **Define clearly things you choose to do, things you must do, things that others could do for you:**

We all have 24 hours to spend in a day and there's nothing to change that fact. So, it's inevitable that at a point you'll find yourself with more things to do than the time to do them. In such situations, being able to prioritise what you need, want, and need not do is important. If you can set aside some things for others, consider doing it to reduce your workload.

- **Schedule certain times:**

Schedule chores for certain times during the day so that you don't lose track of the day on unplanned household tasks. Doing this will not only keep your day open for other activities that you can devote your time to, but it will also contribute to a much better mood throughout the day.

- **Know your own limits:**

Think of this more about time being the limit. If you don't have time, find someone to help with that task, especially if it's not important or your unique expertise.

Practise communicating what your limits are. Express the time constraints to those around you to create clarity and manage expectations. By doing so, you allow them the opportunity to offer help. To change the expectations. To express when the effort might not be as valuable as you thought it was.

- **Ask for help:**

This is the hard part for so many people. For so many women. As a working mum, you're going to have a lot on your plate and it's a

natural but unfortunate thing. What you can do to lessen your workload, however, is to ask for help. Asking someone to share your workload is nothing to be ashamed of and you'll be surprised at how much it can help you alleviate stress.

"But who do I ask help from?", you might ask.

If you can afford it, domestic help can be a great option. There are people who can get your household chores done professionally for a fee. Letting them take charge of your chores can help you get the peace of mind that you need knowing that they have the adequate knowledge on how to get such things done.

Apart from domestic help, you can also ask your partner to chime in with help every now and then. It's not unreasonable to ask them to do so and in fact, most people will agree that managing a family is a two-person job. Your partner should understand that a relationship is the coming together of a team that understands each other's needs and provides the help that they need.

If you have other family members living with you, you may be able to ask them to help as well. Moreover, teaching your kids how to take care of trivial chores early on is a great way to encourage them to be independent. Just be sure to reward them for their help as it will further encourage them to help you out in the future and teach them the basics of how our society works.

3. What you experience in your spaces

Mapping your spaces

Mapping out the floor plan of your primary environment is an essential part of creating space. Whether it's at home or at work, mapping out the floor plan will allow you to understand how to divide your environment into spaces according to the different purposes that they serve for you. In turn, you can use this spatial distinction to organise your work, fun, learning, passion, and anything else.

For example, let's start with your house.

- How many rooms are there in your house?
- What functions do they serve individually for you?
- Which are the rooms that you use for relaxation? (Living room? Bedroom? Balcony?)
- Which are the rooms that you use to be productive? (Study? Bedroom? Lounge?)
- Which are the rooms connecting with family? (Living room? Dining room? The kids' room?)

Analyse and understand these spaces in your house. Multiple rooms may also serve the same purpose, so take that into consideration. You can also apply the same principle for your office to distinguish spaces of productivity, socialisation, relaxation, and so on.

I want you to mentally walk through the spaces in your life. Making a mental map or a scribbled one on paper, we can see the different ways we use space to support us in our everyday life.

What if we had a clear picture of what we intend to use each for?

What if we speak of how we want to feel in those spaces? How do we want others to feel too?

What moments would make up this feeling?

What details bring this to life?

What things distract from the intended experience?

So often we just make the most of the spaces we have. However, the exercise of setting the **intention** of those spaces and the **needs** each space meets for you gives you back control of those spaces.

Making experiences

Once we have mapped out the spaces, aligned their purpose and your needs from each space, we can step down into the experiences that you wish to have in each. You probably already went there as you made that mental map, pondering memories or dreams of the moments you will create there.

This is about curating the sense in each space based on true purpose and grounded optimism.

What you want to achieve there and how you want to be in the space. Just as a cosy sofa or crackling fireplace conjure specific emotions, we can create these moments in everyday life. They don't need to be from a Hallmark greeting card, but rather authentic for you and your life.

Engaging the senses

We rarely live our life thinking about our senses and how we use them to perceive the world, but once you start doing that, it makes so much more sense! As you might know already, us humans have five senses – sight, hearing, smell, taste, and touch.

We experience the world around us with these five senses and depending on how we engage them, the way that we experience it can change drastically. For instance, when we engage our eyes too much through bright and vibrant digital screens (such as smartphones and televisions), they get stressed and aren't as responsive to the outer world as we want them to be.

Being conscious about how and where we engage our senses is a really important part of getting the most out of life. Instead of overwhelming our senses with low quality stimuli that leave us temporarily satiated, focusing on activities that provide a more balanced and wholesome experience can help you get what you want the most out of the different spaces in your life.

As an example, instead of spending your time watching tv or staring at your smartphone, try going out somewhere where you can find natural stimulation. Your eyes are going to thank you for it, and you'll find yourself in a better mental and physical space.

A space for work

When you work from home, it's important to have a workspace that is ergonomic and comfortable. The best way to ensure that is to pay attention to the details in your environment. Try out things and see what does contribute to your productivity and what doesn't.

Here are some tips on what you can do:

- Choose natural lighting when you can

Natural light from the sun is one of those things that can't be replaced with any expensive equipment. Natural light has many benefits for us, and our bodies are programmed to respond to it in many ways.

- It is healthy:

The light from the sun enables our body to produce vitamin D, which is essential for our body. It helps our body maintain bone strength and healthy teeth. Since our body doesn't produce vitamin D inherently, exposure to sunlight is quite important to be able to do so. Our body's clock, also known as the circadian rhythm, is also dependent on natural light, so taking advantage of it can also help us improve our sleep patterns and other timed bodily functions.

- **It is cheaper and more effective as a lighting source:**

Instead of spending money on expensive lighting equipment, using a natural light source can make things much easier and cheaper. Natural light is very consistent and works much better for any kind of work you do.

- **Natural light also helps alleviate seasonal depression:**

For people who have issues with seasonal depression, natural light is a great way to improve your focus at work and avoid getting side-tracked.

- **Use proper lighting and optimal light position for video meetings**

If you find that glare from the window or fluorescent lights bothers your eyes, consider installing blinds or curtains. Uncomfortable lighting can cause unnecessary strain on your eyes, which can be detrimental to your wellbeing and productivity.

- For the best lighting for your video meetings, place a dim lamp in front of your face. Make sure that it's bright enough to highlight your face but not bright enough to blind you.
- If you have a window near your workspace, consider sitting facing it rather than having it at your back. If there's enough natural light from the window, you won't even need a lamp. But even if that's not the case, you should still keep the window facing towards you. A window

behind you will cause the camera to adjust its exposure for the light behind you and make you appear as a silhouette – something that you should avoid at all costs.

- In most cases, you'll not need any other source of light other than the one that highlights your face. Having light sources on your sides can sometimes be helpful, but make sure that it doesn't cause any undesired effects.
- If you have a very dark room or are unsure about your lighting, having a studio lighting kit can be helpful. These kits may take a while to set up, but being designed specifically for the job, they can provide amazing results.

- **Minimise distractions around you to get to the deep work**

Check your energy and how it aligns with your goal. If you're trying to analyse or do something detailed and you have noise and movement stealing your attention, it's time to take stock of what your goal is and what the correct space and time is to achieve that goal.

- **How comfortable is your body as you work? Ergonomics matter for a lot of reasons.**

Your body is just as important as your mind. Design your space to make the most comfort and movement needed in your body.

You want to make sure that you're not straining yourself while performing tasks, which can lead to back problems, neck pain, and other issues down the road. But another benefit of good ergonomics is that it can actually help you be more productive. When you're sitting in an uncomfortable position for too long, your mind starts to wander—which means that time spent working on a task might not count toward completion!

- Clean and green. Get plants and prioritise some fresh air

There's something called the biophilia hypothesis which states that humans have a tendency to be associative with other forms of life in nature. Most of us enjoy spending time in naturally abundant places and this principle can be quite effective to keep you focused when you're working.

While it might not always be practically possible to work in a garden or a forest, what you can do is include plants and shrubs in your workspace to make your environment greener. Plants are nice because they add some life to your workspace—and they're also proven to make people happier.

Having a greener and more natural workspace works wonders on increasing attention span and focus. In fact, there are many studies that show that the presence of plants in our vicinity can prompt our body to release hormones such as endorphins which helps reduce stress levels and boosts our overall mood.

Getting a plant isn't just about aesthetics, though; it's also good for the environment. When you have plants around, they absorb carbon dioxide and release oxygen into the air, which helps keep things breathable. If possible, you should also keep the windows open for better airflow. This can help you stay focused at work for longer stretches of time.

Certain types of pot plants are also known to have special benefits. For example, aloe vera is a very common indoor plant that is known to have many medicinal properties and chrysanthemums are recommended by NASA as one of the best plants for purifying air. You could even grow herbs and spices which might make their way to the kitchen as ingredients when the time is right.

- [Smell – does a particular fragrance or plain fresh air inspire you to feel a certain way? *stimulate senses with intention to empower spaces*]

4. Powerfully present habits - Rituals that you should be following

What is a ritual that serves you in the different aspects of your life?

What actions could you take on a daily or recurring basis that helps you get into the right mindset or state to perform different tasks?

Perhaps there are small things you can do to bring focus to your intention:

1. to prepare for doing hard work,
2. priming to socialise and connect with others outside of your home,
3. for Self-care and renewal,
4. to bring balance if you're burnt out,
5. to switch off from work,
6. to inspire creativity
7. or foster positivity.

I invite you to think of the different states of your being that bring out the best in you. Ponder the small habits, actions and practices you can make that support you to be the best you.

1. Preparing for hard work

When we work hard at something, we are using up more energy – whether it's through physical work or mental. And in order to keep up that energy, there are certain things that can help.

- First, refresh your mind and body before you start. You don't want any lingering exhaustion from before affecting your work.
- Keep anything you'll need nearby. That includes water and food if you're going to keep at it for long. The more you're leaving your workstation for trivial things, the more you're wasting time and energy.

- Visualise your objectives and how you want to clear them. The better you imagine how your day is going to play out in your mind, the better you'll be at judging when you're slowing down. That can help you stay on track for long periods of time.
- Reward yourself when you clear those objectives. Do you like chocolates? Keep a bar with you when you work and take a bite off when you accomplish a difficult task. This works with anything that you like and rewarding yourself this way can be a great way to keep yourself motivated.

Starting your day right

Having a good day-starts with beginning your day well. We all have bad mornings when we are just not in the right headspace. But that shouldn't stop you from trying to get the right start to your day.

Fortunately, there are methods that you can use to get into the right mindset for work. It's still up to you to take control of your life in order to do that, but here are some tips that might help.

- **Sleep early, wake up early**

What's the first thing that you do every morning? You wake up. So, that's where you begin. Get into the habit of waking up early every morning. It has so many benefits even if you're not working. But in order to wake up early, you'll have to sleep early as well.

Waking up early allows you to have extra time on your hands before leaving for work. That, in turn, allows you to finish any chores, do any pending work, or just have a relaxing cup of tea or coffee on your couch. Regardless of how you want to spend your time, it's still a great way to avoid stressing yourself out too much.

- **Get your morning coffee and breakfast**

So many people skip out on breakfast before leaving for work thinking they'll grab something to bite on the way. But that only adds to your stress. You're spending time waiting for your order in line and you're spending money for overpriced store-bought foods. You could save both by simply having breakfast at home.

Skipping out on breakfast entirely, however, is something that you should really avoid. Your body needs fuel to function and when you skip out on breakfast, it can take a toll on your physical and mental health. A hungry stomach can make a person enough cranky to ruin their mood, and of those around them, for the whole day. So, keep this in mind and start your day by providing enough nutrition to your body because it will need that.

- **Be punctual**

There are times when you just can't avoid being late to work. Maybe you had a flat tire or you missed your usual train. In such situations, it can't be helped. But when you start coming to work late often, it can damage your reputation at work. And when that happens, there's just trouble and nothing else.

You don't want to start off your day at work with your boss yelling at you – neither of us do. So, make coming to work on time your second nature. Leave your home just a bit earlier than you usually do to keep reserved time in case something happens that might make you late. Waking up early will allow you to do that easily. It's better to be early at work than late.

- **Be organised**

Being organised at work can drastically reduce your stress levels. When you're disorganised, it can be very easy to get lost and frustrated. You can't find your pen – you get stressed. You can't find the documents you're looking for – you get even more stressed. And slowly but surely,

the stress builds up enough to ruin your day and with that, your productivity.

It's not difficult to get yourself organised although it can seem so when you start thinking about it consciously. The best way to be organised is to stay organised. Keep your devices where they belong. Schedule your work with a to-do list or a planner. Once you start being more organised, you'll be surprised how much it can help boost your productivity.

- **Don't let negativity get the best of you**

Negativity is the greatest enemy of productivity. When you are thinking negative thoughts, you automatically start thinking about everything negatively. These thoughts can build up stress very fast and cause you to lose focus. The best way to not let negativity affect you is to avoid it in the first place. Do you have that one colleague that always has something to rant about? Avoid them while you're at work. Try to identify other potential sources of negativity and avoid them while you're at it.

Self-reaffirmations are also a great way to get the negativity out of your head. Remind yourself that you're there to work and tell yourself that you are able. Start thinking positive thoughts as much as possible. Think about a happy and fond memory or think about the croissant that you've left at the fridge and are looking forward to having after work. Remember, whatever works best for you is the best solution.

- **Greet your colleagues**

Spreading positivity at your workplace is a great way to keep the mood light all around and increase the productivity of not only yourself but those around you. Start the morning by greeting your colleagues – even if that's not something that people do. A simple greeting can make someone really happy and satisfied, and when they greet you back, it's going to make your day as well!

2. Priming to socialise and connect with others outside of your home

Priming is a psychological phenomenon that states that unrelated external stimuli can drastically change how we react to situations in the near future. Simple stimuli such as words and pictures can cause us to react differently to different situations.

“But how do I use this to be more social?” I’m sure you’re asking yourself now.

The practice of priming can be used in many situations and socialisation is one of them. As humans, things like words, pictures, actions, and emotions carry a lot of weight for us and changing even one of those slightly can bring out different reactions in us.

For example, a study conducted by John Bargh in 1996 showed that when different groups of people were asked to unscramble words that were distinctively positive, negative, and neutral, their behaviours were subsequently affected by the kinds of words that they unscrambled. Those who unscrambled “rude words” were more impatient towards the researchers and those who unscrambled “polite words” were more patient. Those who unscrambled neutral words were somewhere in between.

When socialising with others, there are certain ways that you can take advantage of the practice or priming:

- **Stay away from negative words:** Negative words seep into our brain and slowly prompt us to become more negative ourselves.
- **Use positive words to engage:** Using words that paint a positive image in our brain will make subsequent topics and conversations positive.
- **Prime yourself using positive visualisations:** Imagine an image or a picture that makes you happy and cheerful before engaging in a

conversation. Doing so will ensure that you are engaging with a positive overview of yourself and others.

- **Imagine how you want your socialisation to be:** Doing so will allow you to prime yourself to be more positive by imagining a positive result even more you engage in socialisation.

3. Self-care and renewal

Self-care can take many different forms. Sometimes it's about taking a break from physical work, while other times, you want to have the emotional support of someone close to you. Taking care of yourself in every aspect is what true self-care means.

- **Physical self-care:** Physical self-care is about taking care of your physical body. Whether it's remembering to apply lotion before going out or understanding that you need to avoid pushing your body too much, physical self-care is important.
- **Mental self-care:** Along with the body, taking care of the mind is also important. This includes engaging in creative pursuits to allow your mind to grow or doing activities that puts you in a better mental state.
- **Social self-care:** Humans being social creatures depend on each other. Building meaningful relationships with other people is what social self-care is all about.
- **Emotional self-care:** Like our minds, our emotions need to be taken care of as well. Pent-up emotions can start affecting our daily lives in negative ways and figuring out healthy coping mechanisms is the key to avoiding that.
- **Spiritual self-care:** The spirit refers to the whole being including our very existence. In life, true happiness does not come without spiritual happiness, which is why building a healthy spirit is so important.

Being mindful to flourish

What is mindfulness?

It is the practice of being fully present at the moment, with awareness and openness. Mindfulness is a way to train yourself to be more aware of your thoughts and emotions, and it can help you live a happier life. The concept of mindfulness is based on the idea that our minds are constantly thinking, and that most of these thoughts aren't even useful. They're just random words and images that pop into your head without any purpose.

Mindfulness is all about being aware of the present moment instead of letting those thoughts pull you away from what's going on around you. And in a way, it is like taking control of your thoughts. Instead of letting random words and images pop into your head whenever they want, you want to be able to focus on what's happening right now in front of you.

Being mindful can have several benefits which can be especially helpful for people working from home:

- **Reducing stress**

Mindfulness helps you deal with stress by learning how to reduce your reactivity to things. When you're stressed, it's easy to get caught up in your thoughts and emotions. But mindfulness is about being aware of what's happening in the present moment without judging yourself for it. This can help you reduce stress by letting go of whatever thoughts are causing it in the first place.

- **Better sleep quality**

Practising mindfulness before bed can help you fall asleep faster and stay asleep longer. Research shows that mindfulness can help reduce insomnia and improve sleep quality. This is because it helps you manage your stress levels, which are often a major cause of sleep problems. Moreover, your ability to be mindful can help you detach from

the worries of the day, and this is known to have a calming effect on your body and mind. This can make it easier for you to fall asleep at night.

- **Decreasing pain**

Mindfulness has been shown to be effective in reducing chronic pain by increasing patients' ability to cope with it. Mindfulness has also been found to reduce the severity of physical symptoms like headaches. This is because it helps you focus on present-moment awareness, which can reduce the stimulation of your brain that's caused by chronic pain.

- **Better self-esteem**

Practising mindfulness can make you feel more confident about yourself. This is because mindfulness can help you overcome negative thoughts about yourself. It also helps you develop more positive feelings about yourself, which can improve your self-esteem.

How to practise mindfulness

There are a lot of ways to practise mindfulness. In fact, there are so many methods that some methods that work for other people may not necessarily work for you. So, it's up to you to experiment with the idea and find something that works best for you.

- **Meditation:**

By far, the most popular method of practising mindfulness is meditation. This is where you focus on your breathing or other sensations in order to bring yourself into the moment and live in the here and now. This can be done through sitting meditation, walking meditation, or mindful movement.

There are many different types of meditation and ways to practise it. The important thing is to find something that works for you and stick with it. You can also use mindfulness as a way of helping your children cope with stress or anxiety. This can be done by teaching them how to focus on their breathing or by simply taking time out each day to relax together.

- **Pay attention to your actions:**

The easiest is to just pay more attention to what you're doing. Try paying attention to whatever you're doing at the moment with the intention of understanding everything about it. This will not only help you focus more on the task but will also help you learn more about it and gain experience that your brain can actually process to gain information.

- **Focus on breathing:**

Focusing on your breathing can also help build mindfulness. Start by placing your hand on your stomach and breathe in through your nose for five seconds. Hold that breath in for another five seconds. Now slowly exhale through your mouth for five seconds. Repeat this process until you feel calm or relaxed.

- **Living in the moment:**

The last way is by living more in the moment, which means just being aware of what's going on around you without trying too hard to do anything about it. This can be done by taking time to notice what's happening in the moment, such as noticing how the air feels on your skin or listening to the sounds around you. The important thing is not to try too hard but just let yourself experience things without judging them.

Self Compassion

There are many who fear the word self-compassion because they make the mistake of thinking that you always need to be strict with yourself in order to succeed. But that is far from the truth. Self-compassion is about being both critical and considerate about yourself. It is about understanding your humanity and recognising that life is hard no matter whose it is, even your own.

There are quite a few ways in which you can practise being self-compassionate:

- **Learn to forgive yourself:**

Mistakes happen. Humans are very prone to making mistakes and there's nothing wrong with it. Instead of blaming yourself for your mistakes and being too harsh on yourself for it, try to look at the bigger picture and take it as a learning experience. Grow and learn from it so that you can avoid making that same mistake in the future.

- **Know when to stop chasing perfection:**

Chasing perfection is usually a good thing – it helps us grow and keeps us motivated. But when followed to a fault, it can cause unnecessary stress on your mind and body. Try to avoid that and learn to be satisfied with “close to perfection”.

- **Thank yourself:**

When you look back at the things that you have achieved and the goals that you have reached, thank yourself for getting it done. When you thank yourself, you're being self-compassionate to your past self for taking the time and putting in the effort for your future self. And that's something that will help the current you do the same for another future version of you.

- Be mindful:

As we have already seen in the previous section on mindfulness, being mindful is a great way to also be self-compassionate. Being mindful of your actions allow you to recognize and acknowledge the times when you have put in the effort to grow and learn.

4. To bring balance if you're burnt out

Do you sometimes get the feeling that you are exhausted no matter what it is that you do? You try to take a break and then get back to work with a fresh mind, but it just doesn't work?

Fortunately, there are a few steps that you consider if you feel like you're in such a state. The feeling of burnout is often a result of excessive stress that we fail to recognize and acknowledge. Naturally, analysing what may be causing such a stressful reaction is the first step you want to take in order to be able to start making changes.

Sabbaticals are a great way to get away from work for an extended period when you're just not feeling it. There's no shame in it. After all, your mental health is more important than earning money. If you have enough savings and are financially capable, keeping yourself away from work for a few days or weeks is something that you should definitely consider.

Something that you should be careful about is that if a burnout is left unaddressed, it can cause a downward spiral of bad decisions and executions, which can lead to serious issues such as depression, procrastination, and other mental health problems.

5. To switch off from work

Imagine having a switch that you could just flick to get yourself away from work and towards your family, friends, and social life. While we know that such a convenient switch doesn't really exist, there are certain rituals that can get the same job done effectively.

- **Make notes for the next day:**

Wrap your work up by making notes for your next day. Put down anything that you have in mind (ideas, suggestions, etc.) Doing this has several benefits. Firstly, it lets you remember the mental state that you are in when picking up work the next day so that you don't forget the little details. Secondly, putting down these ideas will lighten the workload from your mind and allow you to focus more on your private life.

- **Leave work materials at work:**

So many people have the habit of bringing documents and materials from their work to home. Doing so effectively means that you're bringing your work problems home – which is the exact opposite of what you want when creating spaces in life.

- **Change your clothes and freshen up:**

When you're back at home, before you engage in anything else, go freshen up and change. Comfortable home clothing will automatically put your mental state away from work thoughts and allow you to enjoy the company of your loved ones.

6. To inspire creativity

Creativity is a practice that you get better at the more you do it. There are many who assume that they are not "creative" people, but the truth is that everyone is inherently creative – we just show it in different ways. Creativity

has nothing to do with “talent”. It’s when you want to do something in a different way and find the means to do it either through inspiration or any such stimulation.

- **Visualise your ideas:** Visualising your ideas is a great way to get your creative juices flowing. Most of us find it easier to think outside the box when we can imagine the whole thing in our head. Use methods like mind maps, diagrams, or even rough sketches to find the stimulation that you need.
- **Listen to new music:** Listening to music is a great way to boost your creativity. When you listen to new and unique styles of music, your mind recognizes the creative thought behind it and sometimes that can really help bring out your own creativity.
- **Do menial tasks:** Studies have shown that doing menial tasks such as chores can sometimes help you bring out your creative thinking abilities. These are tasks that do not take up much of your headroom, which allows your mind to keep thinking while keeping your body active.

7. To foster positivity

Being able to stay positive even when nothing seems to be going right is a quality that we should all be striving for. It’s a quality that can be cultivated and one of the things that might help you do that is the concept of “grounded optimism”.

Between the arguments of whether we should be optimistic in life or pessimistic, most of us would usually choose to be realistic instead. It’s a midway compromise between the two and instead of looking at something in an excessive positive or negative light, we choose to view it as it is. However, optimism when based on that reality can be a great way to view

the world. This form of optimism, which acknowledges the negatives and yet, focuses on the positives is called **grounded optimism**.

According to its definition, grounded optimism is a combination of positive attitude and a pragmatic assessment of the situation at hand. In work environments, having a grounded optimistic outlook can be quite helpful for assessing and acknowledging the challenges to meet a goal while still being optimistic about reaching it.

Here are a few practices that you can do to cultivate optimism in your daily life:

- **Be open-minded:** We are all biassed in our own ways due to the experiences that we have gained in life, but there are times when these biases can cloud our judgement. Being open-minded is about understanding your biases and analysing how they may hold you back or affect you negatively.
- **See the good in bad (and the bad in good):** Rarely are things either black or white in life. Learn to see the grey areas of things and understand that anyone or anything can have both negative and positive aspects.
- **Always think of the bigger picture:** Instead of stressing out on a problem and focusing too much on why, try to instead shift your focus on how to find a solution to that problem.
- **Let go of things that are out of your control:** Sometimes, things are just out of our control and there's no helping it. Trying too hard to control things that are already beyond it can affect your mental state very negatively.

Closing out on opening up Space in your life

Creating space around the various aspects of life can be beneficial for anyone who wants to get the most out of life, but if you're a working mom like me, it's something that can change your whole outlook on life.

There was a time when I used to feel overwhelmed by work very easily and it became very difficult to get rid of an indescribable exhaustion from stress. But as I started creating space around the things that mattered to me, so many things became clearer to me that I wish I had figured out earlier.

If you have read this far and tried some of the tips and practices that I have included in it, I'm sure you're starting to feel the same. In this book, we discussed what creating space is about and how to distinguish your spaces or dimensions. These dimensions are:

1. what you need – understanding your expectations and unmet needs
2. how time flies – how you feel about where you spend time; owning and gifting your time, rather than losing it
3. what you experience – engage your senses – sight, sounds, smell, temperature, touch to create calm, creativity, productivity or joy
4. powerfully present habits – tiny actions that add up to meaning

We have also discussed in length how certain steps can help us create spaces around these dimensions.

- **Start with understanding your needs.** You're going to create spaces in your life, so it's natural that you'll want to start by thinking about what you need. Visualising the result before you start is the best way to ensure that you stay on the right track.

- **Manage your time well.** Good time management is the essence of living a healthy and fulfilling lifestyle. The better you learn to manage your time at work, the more time you'll have to focus on things that matter to you the most.
- **Prioritise creating experiences.** Our experiences are what make us. They contribute to our knowledge, our memories, our biases, and so much more. So, understanding what kind of experiences you want in life and working on them can change your life for the better.
- **Practising mindfulness.** Mindfulness is a great way to be more aware about yourself, your actions, decisions, and so on. It gives you the power to judge your life objectively and figure out what's working and what's not.

Finally, if you have implemented these changes in your life and are enjoying the results, it's only natural that you want those around you to feel the same freedom of life, right? Whether it's your partner, your kids, or your friends, when the people around you are happy, it contributes to your happiness and wellbeing as well.

With the mastery of creating space, the next step for you is to "**hold space**". While creating space is about yourself and the life that you want, holding space is all about those around you. Whether you want to be a good support system for your family or a good co-worker, you can find everything you need to know in the next book of the series!

Becoming a mother is an extraordinary journey, filled with countless challenges and immeasurable love. It is a transformation that goes beyond the physical changes and encompasses a profound shift in priorities and perspectives.

From the very moment a baby is born, a mother's heart is filled with an indescribable love. It is a love that is innate, hard-wired by nature, and unconditional. Every struggle, every sacrifice suddenly becomes insignificant in comparison to the joy and happiness brought by this tiny being.

As the role of a mother settles in, the beauty and romance of motherhood may fade, replaced by a deep sense of responsibility. Mothers become the pillars of their households, shouldering the care of their children and the entire family. It is a role that demands selflessness and dedication.

In this journey, a mother's own life takes a backseat. Her time, space, body, and thoughts all revolve around the well-being and happiness of her family. She willingly puts in efforts and makes sacrifices that she would never have considered before. Every waking moment is dedicated to her children, partner, and parents.

There may be moments of doubt, wondering if she is doing things right. But these doubts are a testament to the immense love and care a mother has for her family. The desire to be the best version of herself for her loved ones is what defines motherhood.

There is no one right way to be a mother. Each mother approaches her role in her unique way, guided by her love and instincts. What matters most is the genuine care and devotion she brings to her family.

Being a mother is a journey of self-discovery, growth, and unwavering love. It is relatable to every woman who has experienced the joys and challenges of motherhood.